SPORTS AND POLITICS

NOT JUST SINGH, SEVERAL OTHER POLITICIANS ARE HEADING SPORTS FEDERATIONS IN THE COUNTRY



ARCHERY ASSOCIATION OF INDIA
ARJUN MUNDA
The Union minister of tribal affairs. Association president since May 2019



JUDO FEDERATION OF INDIA
PARTAP SINGH BAJWA Congress MLA from Punjab, elected president in Feb. 2018, though the Delhi HC in June 2022 appointed a retired judge as federation's administrator



CYCLING FEDERATION OF INDIA
PANKAJ SINGH
Son of defence minister Rajnath Singh, also the BJP MLA from Noida, UP. Elected unopposed as president in April 2023



BADMINTON ASSOCIATION OF INDIA
HIMANTA BISWA SARMA
BJP leader and Assam chief minister. Elected president first in 2018, re-elected in March 2022



VOLLEYBALL FEDERATION OF INDIA
ACHYUTA SAMANTA Lok Sabha MP from Kandhamal, belongs to Biju Janata Dal. Elected president in Nov. 2020



ALL INDIA TENNIS ASSOCIATION
DR ANIL JAIN BJP leader, Rajya Sabha MP. Elected president in Sept. 2020



ALL INDIA FOOTBALL FEDERATION
KALYAN CHAUBEY BJP politician and a former footballer. Was elected the federation president in Sept. 2022



NATIONAL RIFLE ASSOCIATION OF INDIA
RANINDER SINGH
Son of ex-Punjab CM Amarinder Singh and a former Congress leader; proceeded on a 'prolonged leave' after completing 12 years as NRAI president

↘ Since April 2023, functions of president being discharged by senior vice president Kalikesh Narayan Singh Deo, a former Lok Sabha MP

*-Compiled by **Rahul Noronha***

careers deterred them from registering a complaint at the time the offences took place.

THE CASE FOR ARREST

The power to arrest or not to arrest rests with the investigating officer of the case. The FIR under PoCSO was filed on the complaint of a wrestler who said she was a minor when Singh first touched her inappropriately on the pretext of taking a picture and then stalking her. Usually, given the seriousness of a PoCSO offence, the arrest is immediate. However no arrest was made between April 28, when the FIR was registered under PoCSO, up to June 5, when it was withdrawn and a fresh statement recorded under Section 164 of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), because the complainant's birth certificate, according to the police, showed a discrepancy.

Provisions of Section 41A of the IPC and several Supreme Court judgments say that an accused does not have to be arrested if the maximum punishment for the offence is under seven years in jail. The various charges filed against Singh do not invite jail time exceeding seven years. Another ground for arrest is the chance of the accused escaping. However, Singh being a public figure was not considered a flight risk.

Deepender Hooda, though, is convinced that political patronage, primarily flowing from the fact that the accused is a BJP MP, is what led to Delhi Police acting unfairly from day one. "Delhi Police had made its intention very clear and you know who their political masters are," he says. "It is shamelessly protecting this guy even from arrests. Arrest is needed in such cases as mostly the accused are powerful men who seek to destroy evidence or influence the witnesses or the complainants and their families, even using money to buy silence."

On its part, the special investigation team of Delhi Police has recorded statements of over 200 people since the FIR was lodged on April 28, a probe that has now gone on for over 40 days. Trying to collect as many corroborative pieces of evidence before filing the chargesheet on June 15, it faced the daunting task in substantiating the complainants' allegations given the incidents reported spanned a decade from 2012-2022 at various venues, including some overseas. Through Indian embassies, investigators have written to the wrestling federations of at least five nations—Bulgaria, Kyrgyzstan, Mongolia, Kazakhstan and Indonesia—seeking any video or photographs along with CCTV footage from the venues and the places where the wrestlers stayed. Delhi Police says all the women believe